

His success led to his appointment as chief of staff of the Ninth Infantry Division in the final assault on Germany, and later as commander of a postwar occupation regiment. Over the next decades, he distinguished himself in several important positions, including commanding officer of the 101st Airborne Division. He progressed quickly through the officer ranks to lieutenant general by 1963, with seemingly limitless career potential. In January 1964, he arrived in Vietnam, and in June took charge of Military Assistance Command, Vietnam (MACV).

Search and destroy

Westmoreland arrived skeptical about the war and the chance of US victory. Although his public stance was invariably positive, in private he was candid in his view that without the ability to go into Laos, the war would be long, difficult, and problematic.

The successful defense of Vietnam's Central Highlands led *Time* magazine to name Westmoreland its Man of the Year in 1965. However, this good fortune would soon change. Limited by political and resource constraints, Westmoreland's war strategy settled on attrition. The NVA and Viet Cong were able to sustain a high body count, which meant that the number of US troops sent to fight them rose to more than 500,000. Public support for the war plummeted.

Wanting to start removing US forces from Vietnam, President Johnson moved Westmoreland back to the US to become the Army's chief of staff. While this was framed as a promotion, many interpreted it as a repudiation of Westmoreland's leadership. For the next four years, he focused on global army readiness, tackling racism in the Army, and creating an all-volunteer military.